has become an extremely difficult proposition. Transfer to non-agricultural use is permissible only exceptionally. Land transfer is mired in so many procedural hassles that direct purchase of agricultural land for non-agricultural use and its conversion for such a purpose is rarely executed successfully.

As a result, the state stepped in and used the Land Acquisition Law to acquire land, in the name of public purpose, for industrial, housing and infrastructural use. The Law, passed in 2013, made it necessary to pay about four to five times the market cost to acquire land for non-agricultural purposes. Indeed, land acquisition through the state for non-agricultural purposes has become a casualty of the law.

All this has resulted in the extreme shortage of non-agricultural land, sending land prices through the roof. Prices have risen to unjustifiably high levels and are outpricing manufacturing in India now. Infrastructure creation is suffering and the residential housing sector is also in deep trouble.

For faster growth and employment creation, India needs five basic land reforms urgently.

Creation of a National Land Record Registry

The land record system in India has evolved over centuries, principally to record data relating to ownership and tilling of agricultural land.

India has been trying to digitize its land records for quite some time. Currently, a programme named the Digital India Land Records Modernization Programme (DILRMP) is under implementation. The data available on the DILRMP-MIS 2.0 dashboard of the Department of Land Resources informs us that computerization of the key land record—the Record of Rights—has been completed in 5.99 lakh villages of a total 6.58 lakh villages, over 91 per cent of villages. The dashboard further shares that